

Diagrammatical accuracy		
	Receptive	Productive
B1	Can infer the time, duration or sequence of an event from the timelines employed. Can understand modified lexical signs.	Can express rhetorical questions in an economical manner, e.g. using just the eyebrows. Can express why one does something (aim: < <i>in order to</i> ... >). Can link two phrases to yield the meaning relation of < <i>although</i> > and < <i>despite</i> >. Can indicate a rhetorical question correctly by leaving a slight pause between the question and the answer. Can establish relationships in the signing space and later reuse these. Can focus on one point on a timeline and/or use temporal adverbials in order to locate an event correctly in past, present or future time. Can make comparisons using adjectives, including superlative forms, e.g. through use of productive signs, changing size, or speed of hand movement.
	Can correctly interpret events in a timeline (past, present or future). Can understand statements indicating intentions (aims, < <i>in order to</i> ... >). Can use non-manual signals to distinguish for example, wh-questions from yes/no questions, or assertions from yes/no questions. Can correctly interpret indexical reference to persons, provided they have been properly introduced and situated. Can identify various strategies for expressing the comparative and superlative of adjectives and understand their meaning (e.g., through changes in the size or speed of the sign or through the correct use of classifiers).	Can situate objects/people in the signing space by indexing and later referencing them with pronouns. Can correctly direct eye gaze in the signing space in order to refer to previously introduced objects or people. Can correctly use different sentence types (statements, questions, imperatives). Can mark questions appropriately, using non-manual markers relevant (e.g. upper body posture plus mimic, eyebrows). Can employ the relevant non-manual elements for the description of a shape. Can employ constructed action in order to convey meaning. Can incorporate number marking into a sign (e.g. to indicate number of persons moving, number of days). Can present a simple temporal sequence by using the signing space. Can support referencing to events in a passage of time with non-manual features (e.g. to distinguish events that are close in time as opposed to events that are distant in time). Can express cause and effect (reason for something).

Diagrammatical accuracy		
	Receptive	Productive
A2	Can recognise and understand condition and consequence in <i>if-then</i> sentences. Can understand clause linkages that express <i><even if></i> / <i><nevertheless></i> relations. Can understand conditional sentences, i.e. under what conditions (<i><if></i>) a consequence (<i><then></i>) occurs. Can understand how sameness <i><same-as></i> and difference <i><different-from></i> are expressed. Can understand differences in meaning that indicate whether actions are carried out by one person or several people, e.g., a person goes v. many people go.	Can express the conditions under which one does certain things (<i><if ... then></i>). Can mark verb agreement consistently, maintaining concordance. Can express a non-causal sequence (e.g. <i><and then ...></i>, <i><and so ...></i>, <i><next ...></i>, <i><after that ...></i>).
	Can identify different types of sentence and their meaning through the word order (statements, questions, orders). Can correctly interpret classifier constructions in simple sentences, provided they are clearly signed. Can correctly interpret verb agreement. Can understand the meaning of basic causal relations (e.g., "I'm late <i>because</i> I got stuck in the traffic"). Can recognise and understand modified handshapes. Can understand indirect messages (questions, requests, wishes, rejection, etc.). Can distinguish between and understand different ways of expressing negation.	Can describe the environment (e.g. landscape) with depicting signs). Can use canonical space effectively to place focus on important elements. Can produce accurate handshapes not only in isolated signs but also in sentences. Can use <i><if ... then></i> sentences. Can express lists and sequences <i><and ...; ... plus></i>). Can employ productive signs correctly in simple sentences.
A1	Can understand an utterance as a direct request, question or order and respond accordingly. Can understand the forms and sizes of objects (e.g., the form of a pyramid) and identify the objects. Can understand different plural forms with simple signs (e.g., plural by means of numbers or by repetition). Can understand lists and sequences (<i><and></i> / <i><both-and></i> / <i><and then></i> meanings). Can understand productively expressed time indicators (<i><day-before-yesterday></i>, <i><3-years-ago></i>, etc.), when the time references are clearly indicated. Can understand from descriptions of manipulated objects how a signer sets/lays them down or places them.	Can use personal pronouns correctly. Can construct simple sentences with SVO and SOV patterns. Can represent the thickness of an object by using productive signs. Can construct a simple sentence using lexical signs. Can form plurals through use of repetition or by marking a number.

6.2. SOCIOLINGUISTIC COMPETENCE

In this scale some elements of sociocultural knowledge have been included, since it is difficult to draw a hard and fast line between the two concepts. In the SNSF research project, a number of descriptors for specific knowledge of aspects relevant to deaf communities were calibrated. Despite being important for understanding local culture, shared knowledge and values, and the meaning of particular signs, some topics that relate to regional culture have been placed in the supplementary descriptors in Appendix 9 and should be interpreted and exemplified by regional values relevant wherever needed.

Sociolinguistic appropriateness and cultural repertoire

This scale is the equivalent of the one for sociolinguistic appropriateness under communicative language competences. In addition to sociolinguistic appropriateness (register, politeness conventions, etc.) some more general elements of cultural and regional knowledge are included.

Key concepts operationalised in the receptive scale include the following:

- ▶ ability to recognise different registers and switch between them;
- ▶ ability to assess the appropriateness of greetings, introductions and leave taking;
- ▶ ability to recognise whether the signer takes into account the social status of a referent or partner;
- ▶ ability to assess the appropriateness of the use of signing space (regarding context and recipient);
- ▶ ability to apply knowledge of sociocultural norms, taboos, appropriate personal appearance, etc;
- ▶ establishment and maintenance of eye contact;
- ▶ ability to understand and apply means of gaining attention or means of giving feedback;
- ▶ ability to apply knowledge of the landmarks of the local culture(s): people, facts and major community issues;
- ▶ ability to deduce social background, regional origin, local ties from the signing of interlocutors;
- ▶ ability to take into account knowledge of the world relevant to communication (e.g. abbreviations, technical aids).

Key concepts operationalised in the productive scale include the following:

- ▶ expression of registers and ability to switch between them;
- ▶ ability to express greetings, introductions and leave taking;
- ▶ ability to sign appropriately with regard to the social status of referents and/or the interlocutors;
- ▶ adaptation of signing space to the context and recipient(s), taking account of local conditions;
- ▶ respect for sociocultural norms, taboos, etc;
- ▶ establishment and maintenance of eye contact;
- ▶ means of gaining attention; means of giving feedback;
- ▶ knowledge of the landmarks of the local culture(s); people, facts and major community issues;
- ▶ ability to provide and judge social background, regional origin, local ties from the signing of interlocutors;
- ▶ applying knowledge of the world relevant to communication (e.g. abbreviations, technical aids, etc.).

Sociolinguistic appropriateness and cultural repertoire		
	Receptive	Productive
C2	Can recognise sociocultural conventions in unfamiliar texts (e.g., appropriate register, polite forms, social status, taboo subjects). Can recognise when the signer gives the characters in a story their own linguistic profile and can describe these profiles.	No descriptors available; see C1
C1	Can recognise the linguistic register chosen by the signer on the basis of the signs used. Can recognise when a signer switches from an informal to a formal register or vice versa. Can judge whether the register employed maintains a distance appropriate to the text. Can infer the social relationship between interlocutors (proximity, hierarchy, etc.) from their remarks. Can indicate a person's social status when they have seen how others address that person (by interpreting the manual signing). Can understand discreet references to persons present when the signer, for example, employs a smaller signing space or holds a hand in front of the index finger so that it is not apparent to whom the finger is pointing.	Can respect sociocultural norms in producing texts (e.g. appropriate register, forms of politeness, status, taboos). Can adapt their register to the audience concerned. Can switch between formal and informal registers without effort. Can express non-lexical difference of register through both manual and non-manual means. Can tell a joke that relates to deaf experiences.
B2	Can deduce from a person's linguistic register their probable background (origin, age, occupation). Can recognise whether the register of a text is appropriate for the target audience. Can recognise whether a text contains all information necessary to enable a target audience with the relevant prior knowledge to understand it. Can recognise a person or character's social status on the basis of manual and non-manual references in the text. Can understand the abbreviations commonly used in the deaf community.	Can gauge whether the public concerned is familiar with deafness and can explain things explicitly if necessary. Can produce lexicalised signs of different registers. Can explain facts and events that are important in deaf communities.
	Can attribute a text to a target audience on the basis of the size of a sign, e.g., big/formal or small/intimate setting. Can assign the text to a formal or informal context on the basis of manual or non-manual features in the introduction to the text. Can judge whether a person introduces themselves to other deaf people in a culturally appropriate way. Can recognise and understand cultural references in texts. Can draw on indirect references to important events, persons and institutions in their own country in order to understand a text.	Can adopt the appropriate formal register in order to maintain distance from the reported issue. Can indicate someone's social status through the articulation of signs in the signing space (e.g. use of a higher locus in signing space to indicate a higher status than the signer's).

Sociolinguistic appropriateness and cultural repertoire		
	Receptive	Productive
B1	Can understand and follow explanations on the origin of culture-specific signs, such as names of well-known people, institutions or places.	Can, as appropriate, engage in greeting/leave-taking remark, according to the type of text and the public concerned. Can present themselves in a manner appropriate to the type of text and the public concerned (e.g. clothes, accessories, personal appearance). ⁴⁷ Can sensitise people to cultural issues. Can, in the course of describing travel, include cultural experiences and aspects typical of the country concerned.
	Can judge whether or not a greeting/leave-taking remark is appropriate for the type of text concerned.	Can introduce themselves to deaf people appropriately. Can use their knowledge of the target sign language culture to explain the origin of certain culturally determined signs (e.g. the names of well-known people, institutions and place names). Can indicate someone's social status with non-manual means (e.g. direction of vision). Can use the sign-abbreviations that are conventional in relation to sign language communities.
	Can recognise on the basis of the sign-language address pronouns whether strangers are addressing them appropriately. Can recognise when someone wishes to be given the floor (e.g., raising a hand, tapping a person's arm).	Can maintain eye contact with their interlocutor while signing. Can accept or decline a direct request or demand. Is familiar with the common technical aids for communication between deaf and hearing people and can name them.
A2	Can recognise differences in register that the signer expresses manually and non-manually. Can recognise whether the interlocutor responds appropriately to a <thank you> etc.	Can use an appropriate means of address when meeting an unknown deaf person. Can adapt the signing space used to the context and the audience. Can take into account aspects of the immediate environment that are important for signed communication (e.g. light, objects on the table).

⁴⁷. These non-linguistic elements relate to the visibility of the author of a sign language text. Learners need to anticipate in production how such factors influence the reception of their text.

Sociolinguistic appropriateness and cultural repertoire		
	Receptive	Productive
A1	Can maintain appropriate eye contact with a signer in a dialogue.	Can greet a deaf person appropriately. Can employ different strategies in order to establish the eye contact necessary for communication (e.g. waving, tapping a person on the shoulder, arm or hand, tapping on the table, turning off and on lighting). Can attract attention in order to acquire the turn (e.g. by raising a hand or waving to gain eye contact, by tapping the interlocutor on the shoulder). Can maintain direct eye contact with their interlocutor. Can use fingerspelling as an aid when communication problems occur. Can give their interlocutor visual feedback through conventionalised phrases and mouthings. Can give their interlocutor visual feedback (positive and negative) using facial expressions and other non-manual elements (e.g. head nod or shake). Can respond appropriately in conventionalised interactions, e.g. replying with a formulaic <i><welcome></i> / <i><never mind></i> / <i><all well ...></i> / <i><thank you></i>.

6.3. PRAGMATIC COMPETENCE

Pragmatic competences cover discourse competences in different media, such as the ability to create personal meaning in the context of a face-to-face or a written discourse and to capture the intentions of language action (e.g. of indirect acts of speech), as well as functional competences such as processing and comprehension even of implicit meaning. These competences also relate to language awareness (metalinguage). Pairs of descriptor scales are available for "Sign text structure" and "Setting and perspectives". In addition there are two other receptive scales, "Language awareness and interpretation" and "Processing speed", as well as two other productive scales: "Presence and effect" and "Signing fluency".

Sign text structure

The focus of this pair of scales is on the ability of the user/learner not only to grasp and understand the structure of different types of text but also to shape and structure their contributions. Sign text structure relates to the scales for "Coherence" and "Thematic development" under "Communicative language competences".

The pair of scales include knowledge of schema for video-recorded texts, e.g. for reports, stories or explanations and knowledge of the ways texts are built and made coherent. They also include knowledge and employment of particular cohesive devices in interpreting a text or in shaping and structuring a video text. The notion "text" is used here without referring to conventional scripts for spoken languages. It is meant to refer to multiphrase signed expressions to convey ideas, thoughts and meanings that serve some function. The notion "sign text" highlights the fact that texts in sign languages were ephemeral before media for recording (monologues) were commonly available. Apart from jokes, particular narratives, prayers and a small number of other genres of text that were handed down in an "oral tradition" and shared in a community, texts remained dialogic in nature. They could not be conserved and were not accessible for discursive examination, educational purposes or argumentative development. This has changed with video.

However, in contrast to written texts, even videoed signed texts cannot easily be skimmed to look for specific information and headings cannot be checked for a rough overview. Nonetheless, specific knowledge of different text types can help to narrow the search space: a thematic introduction will be found at the beginning, a conclusion at the end of a video; the indication of time and place of an event can be found close to each other; summaries are placed at the beginning, conclusions follow the argumentation and so on.

Language users with text competence are able to recognise and assess well-designed as well as fragmented texts and can grasp explicit and implicit meanings. Text competence also requires the competences of all other scales introduced here, for example "Diagrammatical accuracy" and "Sign language repertoire". The text structure scales focus on coherence and the structured development of a signed message, whereas, for instance, the descriptors for "Diagrammatical accuracy" focus on the syntactically correct locations for the use of proforms (handshapes used in place of a previously used sign).

Key concepts operationalised in the receptive scale include:

- ▶ ability to detect the logical development and reconstruct the coherence of a text;
- ▶ ability to understand texts by applying knowledge of text types, schemes, genres, and associated text structures and expected contents;
- ▶ ability to react to gaps in the logical development and misfits of coherence in a text;
- ▶ ability to identify sub-structures of a text (e.g. particular information or chains of argumentation);
- ▶ ability to prioritise different pieces of information based on their emphasis;
- ▶ ability to interpret and weigh explicit and implicit references in a text;
- ▶ ability to formulate expectations on textual content and to use expectations in the employment of appropriate strategies (e.g. when searching for specific content).

Key concepts operationalised in the productive scale include the following:

- ▶ logical development and coherence of the text, with ability to present and justify arguments;
- ▶ structuring information and arguments sequentially with an introduction and conclusion, adding examples and explanations where needed;
- ▶ creating appropriate transitions; placing emphasis;
- ▶ appropriate use of cohesive devices (manual and non-manual, rhetorical, etc.) according to the respective text type;
- ▶ referring backwards and forward in the text.

Sign text structure		
	Receptive	Productive
C2	Can understand logical, causal, temporal or semantic relationships in order to link parts of a signed text to one another. Can distinguish various kinds of evaluative texts from one another (e.g., a controvert text with arguments for and against, justification of an argument, or a philosophical text). Can identify and understand complex hierarchical structures (e.g. in politics and organisations). Can identify missing parts of complex texts or unfamiliar types of texts and infer missing content.	Can mention in passing several other places and people, without losing their thread. Can systematically justify their opinions, for example logically, morally and pragmatically. Can effortlessly use stylistic and rhetoric means to effectively develop their contribution.
C1	Can reproduce the content of a lengthy signed text with various details. Can, after watching a signed text, explain relationships in detail. Can recognise various means of structuring signed texts and correctly interpret their function in the textual context (e.g., rhetorical questions, enumeration, body turns). Can use their own knowledge of types of text to formulate expectations regarding the content and structure of a text and assess its quality accordingly. Can distinguish the separate elements of an argument (assertion, reasons, examples, conclusions) in a signed text. Can predict what is coming next from the order in which elements appear in an utterance, and the emphasis that they receive.	Can develop a convincing, logical argument (thesis, justification, exemplification, conclusion). Can emphasise certain aspects of a complex topic. Can structure complex content in a sensible way. Can employ different types of argumentative texts (e.g. an explanatory text outlining arguments for and against something, or a text giving detailed background and exploring an issue in depth). Can treat a very wide range of topics, introducing and concluding each one appropriately. Can effortlessly employ manual and non-manual, lexical and productive cohesive devices to structure the text. Can adapt the linguistic cohesive devices employed appropriately to the internal structure of the text. Can construct the message of a text from general statements to specific details.
B2+	Can recognise the recurrent, central theme in enacted texts. Can recognise, on the basis of the location of an argument in the signing space, to what opinion the argument belongs. Can identify structural elements of texts and use their functions to understand the text as a whole. Can identify gaps in familiar types of text and fill these coherently by deduction or query. Can recognise whether or not the signer is answering the key questions in a text.	Can formulate an appropriate introduction and conclusion for a text. Can, while concluding, establish a thematic reference back to the introduction. Can organise and formulate content following guiding principles. Can provide recipients who are not present with all the necessary information about the context, so that they can follow what is said. Can group different pieces of information thematically. Can present with images the way an event/organisation is structured. Can use pauses to structure a text (e.g. pausing between different arguments).

Sign text structure		
	Receptive	Productive
B2	Can understand well the content of a clearly structured, lengthy signed text. Can grasp the recurrent, central theme in a text and follow it without difficulty. Can recognise in a signed text the transitions between the introduction, the main text and the conclusions. Can assess whether the introduction and the conclusion of a text fit together. Can recognise a change of topics in a signed text.	Can structure content into categories/topics, situate these in the signing space, and then refer to them through indexing. Can structure the text logically, maintaining a clear development. Can deliver all of the contents and components that are expected for the type of text concerned. Can employ a metalanguage, e.g. to orientate the reader by explaining explicitly in the text the order in which they are doing things. Can create appropriate transitions and links between the different sections of the text. Can highlight the most important aspects of a topic. Can employ principles that govern moving from general ideas to presenting details. Can employ rules that concern going from the general to details. Can indicate temporal relationships between different things related in a report. Can briefly explain a term in the course of a text, when and if this is necessary.
B1+	Can recognise the importance of a statement that is at the centre of the signing space. Can understand references to previously provided information. Can identify connections and relationships between content if these are explicitly referred to in the signed text. Can understand the development of a highly structured signed text. Can recognise means of spatial structuring and use them for understanding a signed text. Can deduce the content of a short text from the context even if local cohesive devices are lacking.	Can structure text content into an introduction, main section and conclusion. Can present content in a sensible order. Can structure a text into a number of thematic sections. Can present clearly the relationships between things by making explicit reference to them. Can point out relevant and interesting details briefly and concisely. Can refer explicitly to what has been said earlier. Can compare the opinions of others and take a position in relation to them. Can relate their own experience to something in the text.

Sign text structure		
	Receptive	Productive
B1	Can recognise simple ways of structuring in a signed text (e.g., a subject and comments on it).	Can formulate the aim and objective of a text in the introduction. Can sequence the successive elements of a text in logical order. Can introduce a topic appropriately, then provide the relevant content. Can indicate the most important aspects of a topic in the hierarchical order of their importance. Can employ simple strategies to structure information (e.g. adding comments on the topic). Can use the sign < palm-up > to mark the end of a particular discourse contribution. Can summarise in a text the most important statements in reply to "when", "where", "who", "what", "how" and "why" questions. Can give reasons for their opinions. Can conclude their contribution correctly (hands together).
A2	Can find the main points in short everyday texts. Can identify and understand simple hierarchical structures (e.g., families, work) by using buoys in signing space. Can understand simple time sequences expressed through the signing space. Can infer the intention/objective of a signed text from the introduction.	Can introduce a topic adequately. Can differentiate the different points in a list. Can formulate simple for-and-against arguments in the form of questions. Can produce a summary on simple topics. Can, at the beginning of a text, give the details necessary to frame the description, providing answers to the key "what", "where" and "who" questions.
A1	Can grasp the individual points in an enumeration. Can recognise the end of a signed contribution by e.g., the clasped hands.	No descriptors available

Setting and perspectives

A key aspect of sign languages is the use of spatial reference. This requires clearly establishing contexts for interpretation by creating a setting. To do so, the three-dimensional signing space is systematically divided. Discourse referents and particular relations must be placed unambiguously within the signing space. Establishing references serves two main functions: it is a means to establish reference relations within sentences (clauses) and it provides a context of interpretation for a text. Sign languages typically clearly introduce the context and setting of a text at the beginning of the interaction or production in order to establish reference points within the three-dimensional signing space. Once established, these reference points remain in place until a new setting is introduced, or an animate referent moves through space. Consistency of spatial relations is therefore essential in order to produce a coherent, unambiguous contribution.

During a contribution, for example in constructed dialogue (reported speech), it may be necessary for the signer to adopt the perspective of a particular referent. Signers can shift between perspectives by leveraging the potential for moving between referential loci (via a body shift or a shoulder shift), or in more reduced forms (e.g. with eye gaze shifts to mark a change in point of view). In all instances, the canonical viewpoint is typically that of the signer. Thus, sign languages and spoken languages use the same privileged viewpoint: namely that of the signer or speaker.

Key concepts operationalised in the receptive scale include the following:

- ▶ ability to envisage signing space and to memorise the relations for the subsequent text;
- ▶ ability to recognise a new setting, change of scene, topic, etc.;
- ▶ comprehension of an action, event or issue that is presented from the perspective of different people or different points of view;
- ▶ ability to follow constructed action (role shifts, shifts of perspectives), constructed dialogue (reported speech), and to recognise the different techniques in doing so, e.g. by body posture, line of vision or other non-manuals;
- ▶ interpretation of manual and non-manual signals and comprehension of setting-related references.

Key concepts operationalised in the productive scale include the following:

- ▶ ability to envisage and plan use of signing space;
- ▶ ability to construct a new setting or indicate a change of scene, topic, etc.;
- ▶ ability to present an action, event or issue from the perspective of different people or different points of view;
- ▶ ability to adopt or change a role (e.g. through body posture, line of vision, depiction);
- ▶ use of non-manual means such as facial expression, posture or eye gaze to indicate different people.

Setting and perspectives		
	Receptive	Productive
C2	Can follow a constructed dialogue between several characters without difficulty even if the marking of role changes is reduced e.g., to the direction of vision. Can follow changes of scene, locations or persons during an action. Can easily follow several changes of perspective and role.	Can present a complex action or event by playing different roles and adopting different perspectives.
C1	Can memorise spatial settings established in signing space (e.g., landscape, family, situation) and follow references within the settings without difficulty. Can fully grasp a setting established in the signing space (e.g., landscape, family relations, situation), even if it is only indicated by depicting verbs. Can recognise when the signer is establishing a new scene for reference (a setting) in signing space. Can distinguish between various perspectives (observer/narrator), provided they are clearly marked. Can recognise what the signer says from their own perspective and what they say from another person's perspective. Can, in their interpretation of the text, take account of the perspective of a participant in the action (e.g., that the character does not see everything).	Can switch between different perspectives. Can create a complex 3-D image including objects in motion.
B2	Can understand a narrative with several characters when the changes of roles are clearly and slowly marked (e.g., by the position of the upper body and eye gaze). Can grasp the spatial references in signing space and use these for comprehension. Can recognise what the signer says themselves and what they say from the perspective of another person.	Can use the signing space correctly while presenting an interaction between more than two people (e.g. family dinner). Can correctly introduce and effect a role shift. Can present a simple action or event from the perspective of a participant. Can present a simple action or event from the perspective of an observer/narrator. Can linguistically correctly construct a new setting when the text requires a new topic or situation to be addressed. Can introduce a setting using just constructed action and depiction. Can present a change of scene, place or person comprehensibly. Can depict the role of a character, e.g. to demonstrate feelings. Can depict a change of character perspective with body posture and/or the direction of vision.

Setting and perspectives		
	Receptive	Productive
B1	Can correctly identify objects and persons that have already been introduced on the basis of the direction of the signer's gaze. Can use location markings established at the beginning of the text and understand subsequent references to it, provided these are clearly indicated. Can identify and remember relative positions of persons/objects and their spatial relationships with one another. Can, in spatial descriptions, understand where and how objects are located.	Can construct a setting in the signing space for a text (e.g. landscape, family, situation) in a linguistically correct manner. Can describe correctly the relative positions of entities with respect to each other. Can demonstrate a change of character perspective through an alteration in upper body posture.
	Can imagine the surroundings, such as the landscape or room furnishings, from descriptions of shapes. Can, by means of subsequent indexical references, once again identify objects and persons previously situated in the signing space.	Can represent the relative proportions and inter-relationships of e.g. a landscape in signing space. Can envisage and describe ideas spatially. Can develop a statement that maps ideas from near to far, and from small to big. Can create a clear image in the signing space. Can employ facial expressions appropriate to a character in a narrative. Can refer to characters in a narrative by using depiction.
A2	<i>No descriptors available</i>	Can use body posture to indicate different opinions in relation to an issue (e.g. by contrasting arguments for and against by a posture oriented to the right and to the left respectively). Can adopt a facial expression appropriate to the character, person or object being described. Can describe a person by using constructed action.
	Can understand simple constructed action where the signer takes another person's role.	Can consistently maintain the relative sizes and proportions of objects (e.g. when peeling a banana).
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Language awareness and interpretation

This scale includes descriptors for competences that enable a correct interpretation of perceived acts of communication as well as of their functions. These competences allow the identification of the respective functions of texts (convincing, amusing, persuading, affecting, etc.) to establish expectations of a text, to understand and evaluate the presence of the signer, and to distinguish different levels of communication. The competences also include the comprehension and assessment of stylistic means, connotative meanings and conscious prosodic signals.

Metalinguistic competences allow for evaluative attributions of specific signs and expressions perceived, for example as an aesthetic contribution or a rhetorical reply. They are applied in the interpretation of a signer's productions as, for example, in a text making an appeal or request, or in a formal text, and they are applied in reflections on signing.

Over and above accessing lexical and productive repertoires, these competences encompass the ability to understand different types of signed statements, such as variation in tempo and style that are not part of the lexicon. Also, in contrast to authors of written text, the author of a signed text usually remains visible: videoed sign texts are not alienated from authors, and the conveyed meanings are not detached from the authors unless they use technological techniques (e.g. an avatar). Therefore, the appearance of the signer may be substantially important for the interpretation of a signed text. Indeed, this is a feature that videoed texts share with face-to-face interactions.

Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ correct interpretation of conscious prosodic signals as well as non-linguistic (non-verbal) signals conveyed by the signer;
- ▶ identification of the intended communicative act as a whole and assessment of the signer's conformity to appearance;
- ▶ ability to distinguish between intended and unintended, communicative and non-communicative behaviour of the signer, its correct interpretations and reflection;
- ▶ correct interpretation of new classifiers, pauses, handshapes, ready-made signs, etc.;
- ▶ correct interpretation of non-manual means, e.g. facial expression, eye gaze, mouthing including mouth gestures (or not), as elements of constructed action and constructed dialogue;
- ▶ distinction of connotative meaning even if conveyed in a non-explicit way;
- ▶ correct interpretation of the rhetorical or structural function of pauses, metaphors, irony, etc.

	Language awareness and interpretation
C2	Can work out the main points of emphasis in sophisticated texts. Can understand aesthetic signing in the context of use, even if they are not familiar with it. Can interpret abstract poetic signs. Can recognise rhetorical and stylistic devices in a signed text and understand their functions (e.g., repetition, rhyme, metaphor, irony). Can understand signing in which the signer combines different stylistic devices simultaneously (e.g., non-dominant hand indicates a context, whereas dominant hand indicates an action from a different perspective, either being combined with non-manual expressions).⁴⁸ Can recognise a variation in the word order and describe its rhetorical effect (e.g., emphasis). Can recognise when a signer employs the sustained hold of a sign as a prosodic or rhetorical device.
C1	Can extract key information on an unfamiliar subject from a lengthy signed text. Can decide whether or not a statement made about a text takes account of an implied meaning. Can correctly interpret metalinguistic references within a signed text. Can grasp unknown concepts by exploiting analogies explained in a text Can distinguish between the use of body posture as a means of structuring the text (e.g., to separate arguments for and against) or as a grammatical device (e.g., for relative clauses). Can understand complicated emotional states that the signer expresses non-manually and by constructed action. Can identify and outline content which is expressed in creative images. Can explain creative language games in which the signer uses, e.g. the handshape, as an aesthetic element.

⁴⁸. This is an instance of "body partitioning".

	Language awareness and interpretation
B2	Can understand conveyed information that is implied, but not explicitly stated in a text (e.g., he went skiing, and I'll visit him in hospital). Can follow the main points of a text even when the signer also makes digressions. Can recognise whether a signer is delivering a complex text in a relaxed or a tense way. Can recognise whether the signer produces a text in a specific rhythm and describe the effect of various rhythms. Can give reasons why the signer inserts pauses in a text, e.g., because they make sense as a structural element or because the signer has to reflect. Can understand who has what opinion and how these opinions relate to each other. Can recognise when a signer's personal experiences influence the argumentation and when they do not. Can determine whether the signing style used is in keeping with the content. Can decide on the basis of the interlocutor's signs and non-manual cues how certain the signer is about what they are saying (e.g., <undecided> / <uncertain> / <probable>). Can distinguish productive signs with classifier constructions from imitative, iconic signs. Can follow the signs made by an interlocutor even when less use is made of non-manual means. Can describe the effect that the sign speed of a text has on them. Can judge whether a person presents themselves in a way that is in keeping with the context and the type of text concerned (clothing, aura, well-groomed appearance). Can deduce the meaning of unfamiliar signs using comparisons and analogies.
B1	Can understand the sequence of events from the sequence of statements made. Can understand simple "for" and "against" arguments on a particular issue. Can understand what advantages and disadvantages a text mentions on a subject. Can understand the key aspects of conclusions. Can recognise and correctly interpret important elements on the basis of non-manual components used for emphasis (e.g., facial expression, size of movement). Can infer from the classifiers used what general term is being talked about (e.g., "murder" from the handling of a murder weapon). Can distinguish between important and unimportant content in a text. Can infer the temporal aspect from the movements of the upper body. Can understand a text so well that they are emotionally affected. Can recognise the non-manual elements employed by a signer to produce tension in the text. Can correctly interpret the <palm-up> sign (e.g., to indicate a pause). Can recognise and understand non-manual markers. Can understand explanations so that they can implement instructions.
A2	Can understand an introduction to a subject and reproduce it in their own words. Can grasp the signer's opinion on a subject. Can relate explanations and examples to one another. Can interpret emotions when the signer communicates these by means of facial expressions. Can recognise whether or not they are addressed as the recipient. Can understand the main points of signed texts on everyday topics Can grasp and indicate the differences between things. Can identify identical references even if these are expressed in different linguistic ways, e.g., by a lexical sign or by constructed action. Can recognise unfamiliar signs in the continuous flow and ask what they mean.
A1	Can distinguish between positive and negative attitudes on the basis of non-manual cues (e.g., eyebrows together v. high eyebrows). Can understand the direct acceptance or rejection of requests/demands.

Presence and effect

The extent of the effect on addressees of one's signing (perlocutionary effects of convincing, amusing, persuading, affecting, etc.) and the specific signs at the user/learner's disposal are the main focus of this scale. There is a focus on the vocabulary and range of structures, including both manual and non-manual elements, and the way the user can exploit them stylistically in order to produce a catchy text. Whether the user wants to demonstrate sophistication, boast or explain, the signer must be aware of their presence.

This includes different ways of presenting a signed statement, such as variation in tempo and style. In contrast to a written text, the author remains visible in sign texts: videoed texts in a sign language are not typically detached from their authors, and neither are the conveyed meanings. Producing a formal sign text, for example, requires an appropriate formal appearance on the part of the signer. Therefore, there is an additional competence in producing signed texts, namely the "competence of appearance" that must be learnt and that includes various aspects of how to successfully produce an appropriate sign text for specific purposes.

Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ sophistication and semantic precision in the overall message (up to aesthetic use at C2);
- ▶ conscious use of rhetorical means, register options, pause structure and discourse control;
- ▶ anticipation of the needs of the addressees in discursive productions;
- ▶ use of productive and established lexicon, including ready-made signs, use of depiction where appropriate and effective;
- ▶ expression of specific functions and vocabulary (A levels);
- ▶ behaviour and appearance of the signer (taking account of the visible environment, accessories, etc.).

	Presence and effect
C2	Can be creative, without losing their train of thought. Can use a wide range of different ways to build up suspense and excitement (e.g. constructed action, rhetorical questions, varying rhythm). Can effortlessly and playfully employ handshapes as an aesthetic element, so that creative forms of language emerge. Can present thoughts and feelings in an artistic way by using a selection of signs and depiction, as appropriate.
C1	Can prepare well, so that while signing they do not need to think about content. Appears calm and relaxed when signing, even when a high degree of concentration is required. Can give the characters in a story their own individual linguistic profile (style, tone, register, etc.). Can use language to develop a narrative in such a way that the recipient can become immersed in what is happening in the story. Can alter the pace of signing (from slow to fast) in order to build up suspense. Can cause the recipients to be carried away by enthusiasm. Can employ exaggeration appropriately and effectively.
B2	Can contribute unconventional and original reflections on the topic concerned in a linguistically skilful manner. Can express their imagination and concepts creatively. Can choose from a broad variety of non-manual means to build up suspense and excitement. Can cause an audience to experience strong emotions (e.g. laughing, crying).
B1+	Can describe an event in an exciting way. Can express complicated emotional states through constructed action and gesture. Can make relevant comparisons that help the recipient better grasp the information concerned. Can stimulate/awaken curiosity on the part of the recipient with regard to the ending to a text.
B1+	Can convey a new point of view in a way that makes the recipients think. Can express the feelings of a person who is close to them. Can use body language and facial expression to convey meaning. Can emphasise what is important by using non-manual means and the extent of movements.

	Presence and effect
B1	Can hold the attention of the recipients by employing various means (e.g. rhetorical questions). Can tell a story in a credible way. Can express personal traits of a character.
A2	Can present themselves in a polite and appropriate way. Can state facts in a neutral manner, excluding emotional affectedness. Can convey and stimulate feelings (e.g. joy, sadness). Can convey emotions through facial expression. Can employ depiction appropriately to express negative and positive feelings (e.g. eyebrows together: negative; eyebrows raised: positive).
A1	Can position themselves so that the signing is easily visible to the recipients. Can express emotional states through depiction only (without the need for lexical signs).

Processing speed

This scale includes competences that describe the ease or effort in comprehending a sign language. The processing speed may depend on familiar versus unfamiliar signs, on the degree of grammatical complexity or on the familiarity with fingerspelling, to give examples. The scale therefore captures how different competences of other scales can be used, how automatised competences already are and how many resources must be allocated in interpretation or are available for further processing of messages. The individual's experience of challenging communication, depending on the language used, relates to this. Processing speed indicates the level of training of a recipient and how well they can grasp and understand conveyed information.

Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ strain of comprehending texts and expressions of differing length, explicitness and complexity;
- ▶ ability to assess the signing speed, regularity and rhythm of others and to monitor oneself;
- ▶ ability to capture actions that are produced with different articulators simultaneously;
- ▶ ability to follow actions with several characters and complex settings;
- ▶ ability to follow messages or texts even if the transitions between the different parts of the text are smoothly signed;
- ▶ ability to understand fluently produced fingerspelling;
- ▶ ability to follow the content despite assimilations, interruptions, gaps, pauses, production errors or unclear signing.

	Processing speed
C2	Can follow texts that are enacted in parallel (e.g., with two signers). Can keep track of who is to take the next turn when several signers are involved, for example, in a panel discussion, by monitoring requests for a turn. Can list the various aspects mentioned in a text even if the signer mentions them quickly one after the other. Can easily understand fluently fingerspelled signs, even if they do not see every letter but perhaps only ergonomic word shapes.
C1	Can follow a long fluidly signed text. Can follow complicated reports without difficulty. Can easily understand complex actions and relationships between objects/persons/places that are described using various classifier constructions. Can follow how people react to one another's communication behaviour even when several signers are involved, for example in a panel discussion. Can understand a signed text even if the signer uses only one hand. Can follow a text even when it contains several unknown signs. Can understand a text even when certain signs or sentences are incomplete or not visible. Can spot signing errors and correct them for themselves without query.

	Processing speed
B2	Can follow unexpected news or video messages without preparation.
	Can easily understand descriptions of actions even if the signer uses different classifier constructions (e.g., manipulators, substitutors).
	Can follow even unexpected twists in a text.
	Can understand rhythmically presented movement sequences and actions, and recognise their aesthetic quality.
B1	Can follow a long and slowly signed text, provided it is shown several times.
	Can follow the narration of a well-known story without difficulty.
	Can recognise and imitate various handshapes, even when the signer uses them in rapid succession.
	Can spot signing errors and ask for more precision or clarification.
A2	Can follow a longer, fluidly signed text, provided it is repeated.
	Can understand a relatively long text in one go, provided it is signed slowly.
	Can understand designations (name, fingerspelled items, functions) for persons in a text and subsequent reference to them.
	Can follow the interlocutor's signs, provided they are clearly visible.
A1	Can understand fluent fingerspelling of letters, provided the producer repeats it, if necessary.
	Can understand short, slowly and clearly signed texts in one go.

Signing fluency

This scale is a direct equivalent of the scale for fluency under communicative language competences. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ the pace, regularity and rhythm of signing;
- ▶ ability to pause where appropriate;
- ▶ ability to articulate simultaneous constructions with different articulators;
- ▶ ability to articulate signs one after another with smooth transitions and without distortion;
- ▶ ability to fingerspell in a fluid sequence to express words for unknown signs (A levels) or context-dependent emphasis (B level and beyond), or as a means of bilingual contact signing (all levels).

	Signing fluency
C2	<i>No descriptors available; see C1</i>
C1	Can sign rapidly in a steady rhythm.
	Can sign a longer text fluently and rhythmically.
	Can employ an extended hold of a sign (hold) as a rhetorical or prosodic feature.
B2	Can sign at a fluent pace, even though some pauses for planning are still necessary.
	Can relate fluently in a sign language a story that they know.
	Can hold a sign with one hand in order to demonstrate something static (hold), while simultaneously using the other hand to continue signing. ⁴⁹
	Can sign at a comfortable pace, without needing to think about the individual signs.
	Can use pauses for effect at appropriate points.
A2	Can rhythmically represent the stages of a movement or activity (e.g. leaves falling down, hail).
	Can fingerspell fluently, connecting or blending elements smoothly.

⁴⁹. These constructions are also known as “fragment buoys”.

	Signing fluency
B1	Can sign a fluent transition between related points.
	Can sign a short text rhythmically.
	Can employ sequences of handshapes and/or the handshapes for fingerspelling fluently.
A2	Can sign a simple sentence rhythmically.
	Can indicate the end of a sentence clearly by leaving a pause.
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

APPENDICES

Appendix 1

SALIENT FEATURES OF THE CEFR LEVELS

Level A1 is considered the lowest level of generative language use – the point at which the learner can “interact in a simple way, ask and answer simple questions about themselves, where they live, people they know, and things they have, initiate and respond to simple statements in areas of immediate need or on very familiar topics”, rather than relying purely on a very finite rehearsed, lexically organised repertoire of situation-specific phrases.

Level A2 does appear to reflect the level referred to by the “Waystage” specification. It is at this level that the majority of descriptors stating social functions are to be found, like “use simple everyday polite forms of greeting and address”; “greet people, ask how they are and react to news”; “handle very short social exchanges”; “ask and answer questions about what people do at work and in free time”; “make and respond to invitations”; “discuss what to do, where to go and make arrangements to meet”; “make and accept offers”. Here too are to be found descriptors on getting out and about: the simplified cut-down version of the full set of transactional specifications in “The Threshold Level” for adults living abroad, like: “make simple transactions in shops, post offices or banks”; “get simple information about travel”; “use public transport: buses, trains, and taxis, ask for basic information, ask and give directions, and buy tickets”; “ask for and provide everyday goods and services”.

The next band represents a “strong Waystage” (A2+) performance. What is noticeable here is more active participation in conversation given some assistance and certain limitations, for example: “initiate, maintain and close simple, restricted face-to-face conversation”; “understand enough to manage simple, routine exchanges without undue effort”; “make themselves understood and exchange ideas and information on familiar topics in predictable everyday situations, provided the other person helps if necessary”; “communicate successfully on basic themes if they can ask for help to express what they want to”; “deal with everyday situations with predictable content, though they will generally have to compromise the message and search for words/signs”; “interact with reasonable ease in structured situations, given some help, but participation in open discussion is fairly restricted”; plus significantly more ability to sustain monologues, for example: “express how they feel in simple terms”; “give an extended description of everyday aspects of their environment, e.g. people, places, a job or study experience”; “describe past activities and personal experiences”; “describe habits and routines”; “describe plans and arrangements”; “explain what they like or dislike about something”; “give short, basic descriptions of events and activities”; “describe pets and possessions”; “use simple descriptive language to make brief statements about and compare objects and possessions”.

Level B1 reflects the “Threshold Level” specification for a visitor to a foreign country and is perhaps most obviously categorised by two features. The first feature is the ability to maintain interaction and get across what you want to, in a range of contexts, for example: “generally follow the main points of extended discussion around them, provided people articulate clearly in standard language”; “give or seek personal views and opinions in an informal discussion with friends”; “express the main point they want to make comprehensibly”; “exploit a wide range of simple language flexibly to express much of what they want to”; “maintain a conversation or discussion but may sometimes be difficult to follow when trying to express exactly what they would like to”; “keep going comprehensibly, even though pausing for grammatical and lexical planning and repair is very evident, especially in longer stretches of free production”. The second feature is the ability to cope flexibly with problems in everyday life, for example “cope with less routine situations on public transport”; “deal with most situations likely to arise when making travel arrangements through an agent or when actually travelling”; “enter unprepared into conversations on familiar topics”; “make a complaint”; “take some initiatives in an interview/consultation (e.g. to bring up a new subject) but is very dependent on interviewer in the interaction”; “ask someone to clarify or elaborate what they have just said”.

The subsequent band seems to be a “strong Threshold” (B1+). The same two main features continue to be present, with the addition of a number of descriptors that focus on the exchange of “quantities” of information, for example: “take messages communicating enquiries, explaining problems”; “provide concrete information required in an interview/consultation (e.g. describe symptoms to a doctor) but does so with limited precision”; “explain why something is a problem”; “summarise and give their opinion about a short story, article, talk, discussion, interview or documentary and answer further questions of detail”; “carry out a prepared interview, checking and confirming information, though they may occasionally have to ask for repetition if the other person’s response is rapid or extended”; “describe how to do something, giving detailed instructions”; “exchange accumulated factual information on familiar routine and non-routine matters within their field with some confidence”.

Level B2 represents a new level as far above B1 (“Threshold”) as A2 (“Waystage”) is below it. It is intended to reflect the “Vantage Level” specification. The metaphor is that having been progressing slowly but steadily across the intermediate plateau, the user/learner finds they have arrived somewhere, things look different, they acquire a new perspective, can look around them in a new way. This concept does seem to be borne out to a considerable extent by the descriptors calibrated at this level. They represent quite a break with the content so far. For example, at the lower end of the band there is a focus on effective argument: “account for and sustain their opinions in discussion by providing relevant explanations, arguments and comments”; “explain a viewpoint on a topical issue giving the advantages and disadvantages of various options”; “construct a chain of reasoned argument”; “develop an argument giving reasons in support of or against a particular point of view”; “explain a problem and make it clear that their counterpart in a negotiation must make a concession”; “speculate about causes, consequences, hypothetical situations”; “take an active part in informal discussion in familiar contexts, commenting, putting their point of view clearly, evaluating alternative proposals and making and responding to hypotheses”. Secondly, running right through the level there are two new focuses. The first is being able to more than hold your own in social discourse: for example, “converse naturally, fluently and effectively”; “understand in detail what is said to them in the standard language even in an [audially/visually] noisy environment”; “initiate discourse, take their turn when appropriate and end conversation when they need to, though they may not always do this elegantly”; “use stock phrases (e.g. “That’s a difficult question to answer”) to gain time and keep the turn while formulating what to say”; “interact with a degree of fluency and spontaneity that makes regular interaction with users of the target language quite possible without imposing strain on either party”; “adjust to the changes of direction, style and emphasis normally found in conversation”; “sustain relationships with users of the target language without unintentionally amusing or irritating them or requiring them to behave other than they would with another proficient user”. The second new focus is a new degree of language awareness: “correct mistakes if they have led to misunderstandings”; “make a note of their recurrent mistakes and consciously monitor their language”; “generally correct slips and errors if they become conscious of them”; “plan what is to be said and the means to say it, considering the effect on the recipient(s)”. In all, this does seem to be a new threshold for a language learner to cross.

At the next band – representing a “strong Vantage” (B2+) performance – the focus on argument, effective social discourse and on language awareness that appears at B2 (“Vantage”) continues. However, the focus on argument and social discourse can also be interpreted as a new focus on discourse skills. This new degree of discourse competence shows itself in conversational management (co-operating strategies): “give feedback on and follow up statements and inferences by others and so help the development of discussion”; “relate own contribution skilfully to those of others”. It is also apparent in relation to coherence/cohesion: “use a limited number of cohesive devices to link sentences together smoothly into clear, connected discourse”; “use a variety of linking expressions efficiently to mark clearly the relationships between ideas”; “develop an argument systematically with appropriate highlighting of significant points, and relevant supporting detail”. Finally, it is at this band that there is a concentration of items on “negotiating”: “outline a case for compensation, using persuasive language and simple arguments to demand satisfaction”; “state clearly the limits to a concession”.

Level C1, seems to be characterised by good access to a broad range of language, which allows fluent, spontaneous communication, as illustrated by the following examples: “Can express themselves fluently and spontaneously, almost effortlessly. Has a good command of a broad lexical repertoire allowing gaps to be readily overcome with circumlocutions. There is little obvious searching for expressions or avoidance strategies”; “only a conceptually difficult subject can hinder a natural, smooth flow of language”. The discourse skills characterising the previous band continue to be evident at Level C1, with an emphasis on more fluency, for example: “select a suitable phrase from a fluent repertoire of discourse functions to preface their remarks in order to get the floor, or to gain time and keep it while thinking”; “produce clear, smoothly flowing, well-structured language, showing controlled use of organisational patterns, connectors and cohesive devices”.

Level C2 is not intended to imply native-speaker or near native-speaker competence. What is intended is to characterise the degree of precision, appropriateness and ease with the language that typifies the speech of those who have been highly successful learners. Descriptors calibrated here include: “convey finer shades of meaning precisely by using, with reasonable accuracy, a wide range of modification devices”; “has a good command of idiomatic expressions and colloquialisms with awareness of connotative levels of meaning”; “backtrack and restructure around a difficulty so smoothly the interlocutor is hardly aware of it”.

The Common Reference Levels can be presented and exploited in a number of different formats, in varying degrees of detail. Yet the existence of fixed points of common reference offers transparency and coherence, a tool for future planning and a basis for further development.

The Common Reference Levels are summarised in the following table:

Proficient user	C2	Can understand virtually all types of texts. Can summarise information from different oral and written sources, reconstructing arguments and accounts in a coherent presentation. Can express themselves spontaneously, very fluently and precisely, differentiating finer shades of meaning even in more complex situations.
	C1	Can understand a wide range of demanding, longer texts, and recognise implicit meaning. Can express themselves fluently and spontaneously without much obvious searching for expressions. Can use language flexibly and effectively for social, academic and professional purposes. Can produce clear, well-structured, detailed text on complex subjects, showing controlled use of organisational patterns, connectors and cohesive devices.
Independent user	B2	Can understand the main ideas of complex text on both concrete and abstract topics, including technical discussions in their field of specialisation. Can interact with a degree of fluency and spontaneity that makes regular interaction with users of the target language quite possible without imposing strain on either party. Can produce clear, detailed text on a wide range of subjects and explain a viewpoint on a topical issue giving the advantages and disadvantages of various options.
	B1	Can understand the main points of clear standard input on familiar matters regularly encountered in work, school, leisure, etc. Can deal with most situations likely to arise while travelling in an area where the language is spoken. Can produce simple connected text on topics which are familiar or of personal interest. Can describe experiences and events, dreams, hopes & ambitions and briefly give reasons and explanations for opinions and plans.
Basic user	A2	Can understand sentences and frequently used expressions related to areas of most immediate relevance (e.g. very basic personal and family information, shopping, local geography, employment). Can communicate in simple and routine tasks requiring a simple and direct exchange of information on familiar and routine matters. Can describe in simple terms aspects of their background, immediate environment and matters in areas of immediate need.
	A1	Can understand and use familiar everyday expressions and very basic phrases aimed at the satisfaction of needs of a concrete type. Can introduce themselves and others and can ask and answer questions about personal details such as where someone lives, people they know and things they have. Can interact in a simple way provided the other person talks slowly and clearly and is prepared to help.